Robotics Team Commitment, Attendance, and Accountability Policy

Quick Overview for Team Members

(So you don't have to read the entire document)

1. We Are a Team, and Commitment Matters.
This is a year-round competitive robotics program, not just a casual club. A lot of work goes into what we do, and when someone doesn't show up or do their part, it hurts the entire team. It's unfair to the members who consistently put in the work. When you commit to a competition, your teammates are counting on you.

2. You Choose Which Competitions You Participate In.
You are not required to participate in every competition. We have two seasons: BEST Robotics and BattleBots/Rocketry. You can participate in one or both, but once you commit to a season, you're expected to follow through.

3. Minimum 70% Attendance Per Season.
You must attend at least 70% of meetings, with 75% or higher being the goal. Attendance will be tracked separately for each season. You cannot use attendance from BEST to make up for missed BattleBots/Rocketry meetings, or vice versa.

4. We Understand You Have Other Responsibilities.
Sports, work, school, illness, family matters, and other reasonable circumstances are understood. Communicate with leadership, and we'll try to work around scheduling conflicts when possible. Approved excused absences will not count against you.

5. One Formal Warning, Then Suspension.
If your attendance drops below 70% because of unexcused absences, we will meet to discuss the issue. **That meeting is your formal warning.** Leadership may also contact your parents depending on the situation. If you continue missing meetings without a valid excuse after that warning, you will be suspended. There will not be repeated warnings.

6. Kickoff and Competition Day Are Mandatory.
If you're participating in a competition, you are required to attend kickoff and competition day unless you have a valid excuse. These events are especially important and are not optional.

7. Missing Competition Day Has Serious Consequences.
Missing competition without a valid excuse can result in suspension, temporary disqualification from the team, or significantly reduced responsibilities going forward. If you have a legitimate reason, we'll discuss the situation before making a decision.

8. Important Roles Are Earned.
Students who consistently show up, work hard, learn their responsibilities, and demonstrate reliability will be given greater consideration for important competition roles. If you rarely participate or don't fulfill your commitments, you should not expect to be given a major role.

9. Know the Game and Your Responsibilities.
Everyone is expected to learn the competition rules outside of regular meetings, understand their assigned responsibilities, and come prepared to contribute.

10. Communication and Documentation Are Required.
Everyone must actively use our Google Drive to access and maintain team documents, designs, and other important information. Keep your work organized and communicate with your teammates.

11. Work Together and Take Initiative.
Take ownership of your responsibilities, help your teammates, and look for ways to contribute. Our success depends on everyone doing their part.

12. Our Goal Is to Build a Winning Program.
We're here to learn engineering, develop valuable skills, compete, and create opportunities for our futures. We want to win, but that takes effort, preparation, and teamwork. These rules exist to help us get there.

1. Team Philosophy and Expectations

Our robotics program is a competitive, year-round team dedicated to engineering, innovation, teamwork, and success.

This is not simply a club that meets occasionally or participates in one competition each year. We are working to build a serious, competitive program where students can develop technical skills, gain valuable experience, pursue scholarship and college opportunities, and compete at a high level.

Achieving these goals requires commitment.

Just like participating in a competitive sport, being part of this team requires consistent effort, preparation, and responsibility.

When you commit to participating in a competition season, you are giving your word to your teammates that they can depend on you.

A tremendous amount of time and effort goes into designing, building, programming, testing, and preparing our robots.

When members fail to show up or fulfill their responsibilities without reasonable justification, it affects the entire team. Work falls behind, other members must compensate, morale suffers, and our chances of winning decrease.

It is unfair to the students who consistently attend meetings, complete their responsibilities, and put in the effort to succeed.

Our team will prioritize students who demonstrate commitment, dependability, and a willingness to work.

We understand that students have lives and responsibilities outside of robotics. Legitimate circumstances will be considered, and reasonable accommodations will be made when possible.

However, choosing to participate means accepting the responsibilities that come with being part of the team.

These rules exist to establish clear expectations, protect the team's progress, and ensure that leadership can focus on teaching engineering, developing students, building robots, and preparing for competition.

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2. Competition Seasons and Participation

The robotics program is divided into two competition seasons:

Season 1: BEST Robotics

- **BEST Robotics meetings, projects, kickoff, and competition.**

Season 2: BattleBots and Rocketry

- **BattleBots and Rocketry meetings, projects, and competitions.**

BattleBots and Rocketry are grouped into the same season for attendance purposes.

Students may choose which competitions they want to participate in.

Participation in every competition is not required.

However, once a student commits to a competition season, they are responsible for meeting that season's requirements.

3. Attendance Requirements

All participating members must maintain a minimum of 70% attendance during each competition season, with an expected target of 75% or higher.

Attendance will be officially recorded and monitored.

Attendance percentages are calculated separately for each competition season.

Attendance cannot be transferred between seasons.

For example, a student cannot miss most of the BattleBots/Rocketry season and compensate by attending every BEST Robotics meeting.

Attendance Standards

Attendance	Status
75–100%	**Meets attendance expectations**
70–74%	**Meets minimum requirements**
Below 70% due to unexcused absences	**Formal warning and meeting with leadership**

Approved excused absences will not count against a student's required attendance percentage.

4. Scheduling Conflicts and Excused Absences

Students are expected to communicate known scheduling conflicts and anticipated absences to team leadership.

We understand that members may have other responsibilities, including:

- **Sports and school activities.**
- **Jobs and work schedules.**
- **Medical appointments or illness.**
- **Family obligations and emergencies.**
- **Other reasonable circumstances.**

Leadership will make reasonable efforts to schedule meetings around known conflicts whenever possible.

However, accommodating every individual schedule may not always be possible.

Students who communicate legitimate scheduling conflicts will not be treated the same as students who repeatedly fail to attend without explanation.

Excuses will be evaluated based on the circumstances, and leadership will determine whether an absence is considered excused.

Unexpected emergencies will be considered even when advance notice was not possible.

5. Attendance Violations and Disciplinary Action

Attendance requirements will be enforced through a direct, two-step process.

Step 1: Formal Warning

If leadership identifies an attendance issue, including a student falling below 70% attendance due to unexcused absences, the student will be required to meet with team leadership.

This meeting serves as the student's formal warning.

During the meeting, the attendance issue will be explained, and the student will have an opportunity to discuss any relevant circumstances.

Leadership will communicate that the student's attendance must improve and that continued unexcused absences will result in suspension.

Depending on the circumstances, leadership may also communicate with the student's parent or guardian through a written notice, direct message, phone call, or another appropriate method.

The method of parent communication will be determined by leadership based on the situation.

Step 2: Suspension

If a student continues to miss meetings without valid excuses after receiving their formal warning, they will be suspended from the team.

There will be no additional warnings or repeated disciplinary meetings before suspension.

The length and conditions of the suspension will be determined by team leadership.

Members are expected to correct attendance problems after receiving their formal warning.

6. Mandatory Kickoff and Competition Attendance

Kickoff and competition day are mandatory for students participating in the respective competition.

These events are separate from the regular meeting attendance percentage and are required regardless of whether a student has otherwise met the 70% minimum.

Kickoff

Members are required to attend kickoff unless they have a valid excuse approved by leadership.

Missing kickoff without a valid excuse is a violation of team expectations and may result in disciplinary action.

Competition Day

Members who commit to participating in a competition are required to attend competition day unless they have a valid excuse.

Missing competition day without a valid excuse will result in serious disciplinary consequences.

Depending on the circumstances, consequences may include:

- **Suspension from the team for a period determined by leadership.**
- **Disqualification from participation in future team activities or competitions for a specified period.**
- **Significant reduction or removal of important team responsibilities.**

Leadership will determine the appropriate consequence based on the situation.

Valid Excuses

Students who miss kickoff or competition due to illness, family emergencies, or other legitimate circumstances will have those circumstances considered.

If a student provides an explanation for missing competition, leadership will discuss the situation and determine whether the absence was justified.

An absence supported by a valid excuse will not automatically result in disciplinary action.

7. Team Roles and Responsibilities

Important team positions and competition roles are earned through participation, effort, knowledge, and dependability.

The more consistently a student contributes and demonstrates reliability, the greater the opportunities they will have to take on important responsibilities.

Leadership will consider the following when assigning roles:

- **Attendance and participation.**
- **Technical knowledge and ability.**
- **Completion of assigned responsibilities.**
- **Reliability and communication.**
- **Demonstrated effort and initiative.**
- **Teamwork and leadership.**

Students who consistently attend, contribute, and develop their skills will receive greater consideration for important competition roles.

Students who repeatedly miss meetings or fail to fulfill their responsibilities without valid excuses will not be assigned critical roles that require a high level of dependability.

Attendance alone does not guarantee a position. Members must also demonstrate the knowledge and ability necessary to perform their assigned responsibilities.

8. Member Acknowledgment

By joining the robotics team and committing to a competition season, members acknowledge that:

1. **They understand the attendance requirements for their chosen competition season.**
2. **They are responsible for communicating absences and scheduling conflicts.**
3. **They understand that attendance will be tracked separately for each season.**
4. **They understand that falling below the attendance threshold due to unexcused absences will result in a formal warning.**
5. **They understand that continued unexcused absences following a formal warning will result in suspension.**
6. **They understand that kickoff and competition attendance are mandatory unless a valid excuse is provided.**
7. **They understand that unexcused competition-day absences may result in suspension, disqualification, or significantly reduced responsibilities.**
8. **They understand that important team roles are earned through commitment, demonstrated ability, and reliability.**

Participation in this team is voluntary. Once a commitment is made, members are expected to honor it.